(NGOs), both guaranteeing their right to exist, and mandating their obligation to “coordinate” and “collaborate” with the government and its official organizations.[47] The number of NGOs mushroomed in the early 1990s.

The limits to the new space for NGOs were revealed in March of 1996, when Raúl Castro made a televised speech attacking scholars who he claimed had sold themselves to the enemy, accepting foreign funding, privileges, and travel in exchange for writings tailored to outside goals. In particular, he mentioned the Centro de Estudios sobre América (CEA), a prominent Havana think tank that had produced a good deal of significant and challenging work on Cuba’s economic and political direction.[48]

The CEA case reveals the subtle and complex ways that intellectual freedom is managed in Cuba. Some restrictions are enforced in harsh and overt ways, well documented and known on the outside. But prison sentences are reserved for Cubans accused and convicted of conspiring with outside forces (i.e., the United States) for the overthrow of the Cuban government. In the CEA case, nobody was formally charged or judicially punished. The head of the Center, who had encouraged much of the innovative work there, was demoted, replaced by a Communist Party hardliner. Several others also lost their positions, and a number of researchers chose to leave. Most of them found new homes in other Cuban research facilities, but a few of them left the country.

Another Cuban organization that pressed the limits during the Special Period was Magín. Magín was begun in 1993 by a small group of professionals distressed with the continuing gender inequality and, in particular, the ways that women’s bodies were being used to sell the island to tourists. “They were outraged by images of seductive mulatas, their full buttocks barely covered by bikini thongs, and full-breasted sex objects beckoning from beneath the ever-present royal palm.”[49] Despite the suspicion of the FMC, Magín members published, held workshops, and met with international feminist groups. But the FMC undercut Magín members’ invitation to the 1995 World Conference on Women in Beijing, insisting that the FMC had filled all of the slots available for